

Virtually all car or home insurers look at your claims history whenever you apply for new coverage; if you have a lot of claims on your record, they may think you're likely to cost them a lot of money down the road.

You're entitled to a free copy of your auto and home claim reports every year. Go to www.choicetrust.com to get yours.

- **Consider getting your home and auto insurance from the same company.** Some auto insurers will give you a better deal if you insure the rest of your earthly possessions with them. (Renters insurance usually counts.)
- **Take a class.** Many auto insurers will offer discounts of 10% to 15% if you take a defensive driving class, which can cost about \$30 to \$40. Some will let you take the course online or watch a DVD.
- **Get insured through an “affinity group.”** As with other kinds of insurance, you can sometimes get a break on car insurance by belonging to a certain group, such as an alumni association or a trade union. Some insurers even offer discounts to people who buy hybrid cars. (The reason: Hybrid owners tend to be safer, more conscientious drivers.) Your employer may also offer group auto insurance.
- **Stay close to your parents.** Find out what insurance company your parents use; some insurers will give you a break if your parents are customers. In fact, I know of one insurer that gives the kids of existing policy holders up to a 50% discount until they turn 27.
- **Check with your state's insurance department.** Some state insurance departments publish lists of companies and prices. (See Figure 8–1 for websites and phone numbers.)

↓ **DISABILITY INSURANCE**